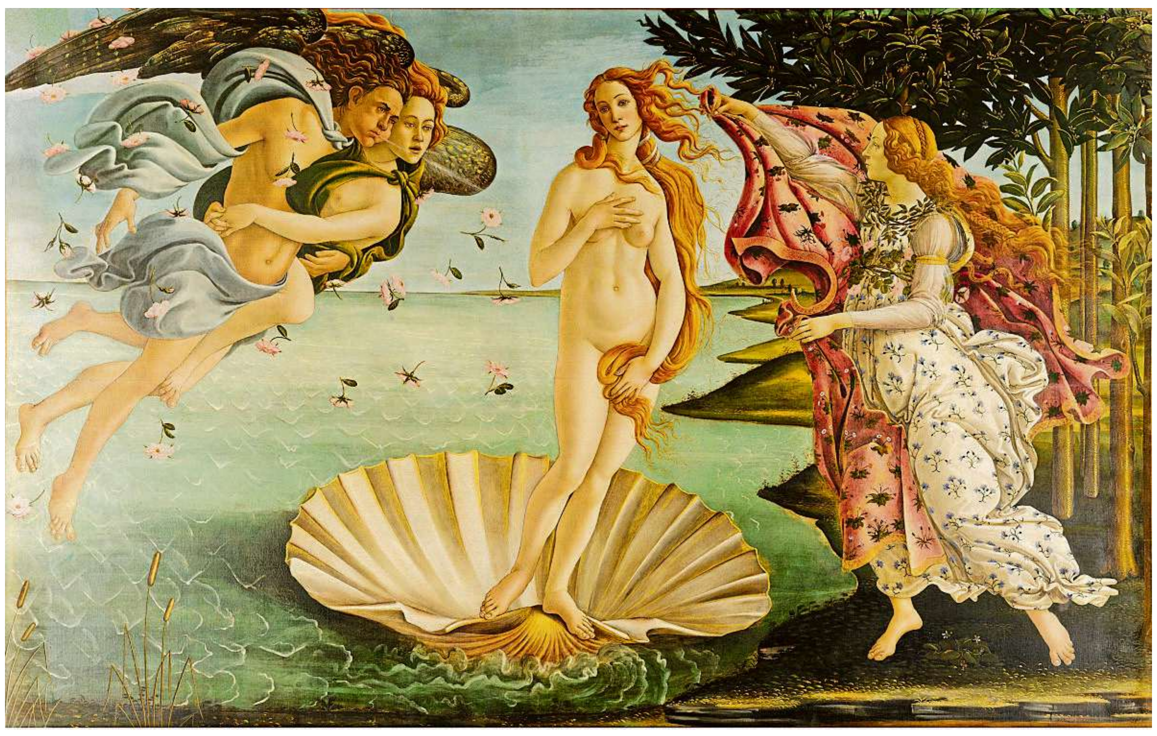
DIFFERENT STROKES

The rise and fall of Botticelli

Considered one of the most creative painters of the Renaissance, the Florentine master faded from public memory and was rediscovered centuries later, writes Giridhar Khasnis



La nascita di Venere. (PIC COURTESY: WIKIMEDIA/GOOGLE ART PROJECT)

Five hundred and fifty years ago, on April 26, 1476, a young woman died in Florence. She was barely 23. Her body was carried through the streets in an open coffin, viewed by a heartbroken crowd before her burial in the Church of Ognissanti. Legend holds that the entire city entered a period of mourning to mark its collective grief.

Known for her exceptional grace, Simonetta Vespucci — celebrated as La Bella Simonetta — was one of the most admired women of Renaissance Florence. Born in 1453 into a wealthy Genoese family, she was barely 16 when she married Marco Vespucci and entered Florence's powerful elite. Praised by poets, adored by Lorenzo de Medici's ruling circle, and immortalised by the finest painters of the age, her face came to represent the supreme vision of Western feminine beauty.

Among those deeply moved by the beauty of Simonetta was Sandro Botticelli (1445–1510), one of the most original and creative painters of the Italian Renaissance. Trained under Filippo Lippi and heavily patronised by the Medici court, Botticelli emerged as a distinctive master of the Florentine Renaissance.

Unlike the anatomical realism and heavy musculature later championed by Leonardo da Vinci (1452-1519) or Michelangelo (1475-1564), Botticelli's style relied on delicate line, rhythmic motion, and a dream-like idealisation. His figures seemed suspended between physical reality and divine fantasy. Sweeping golden hair, pale skin, elongated limbs, and melancholy expressions defined his canvas, transforming physical beauty into a metaphor for virtue, love, and spiritual contemplation. His contribution to the decoration of the Sistine Chapel in Rome confirmed his stature among the leading artists of his age.

Popular tradition has long insisted that Simonetta was Botticelli's ultimate muse — the face behind his grandest mythological works, including Primavera and The Birth of Venus, both painted in the 1480s. Some historians have suggested a deep platonic devotion, citing Botticelli's request to be buried at the foot of her tomb in the Vespucci parish church of Ognissanti.

Many other historians remain sceptical of a romantic relationship between the two. The Birth of Venus was completed in 1486 — nearly a decade after Simonetta's tragic death — and no surviving document proves she ever sat as Botticelli's live model. Yet the myth persists because Botticelli's painted faces mirror the exact qualities attributed to Simonetta in life: an incredible grace, quiet vulnerability, and ethereal radiance.

Portrait of Simonetta Vespucci as Nymph. (PIC COURTESY: WIKIMEDIA/GOOGLE ART PROJECT)

Probable self-portrait. (PIC COURTESY: WIKIMEDIA)

Most famous creation

The Birth of Venus remains Botticelli's most famous creation. It depicts the goddess of love arriving on the shores of Cyprus, floating atop a giant scallop shell while Zephyr, the west wind, blows her towards land amidst a shower of pink roses.

The work marked a monumental departure from medieval religious tradition. It was painted on canvas rather than the traditional wooden panel. More importantly, it brought large-scale classical nudity into secular Renaissance art. Rather than pursuing anatomical accuracy, Botticelli deliberately sacrificed natural proportions for line, rhythm and grace.

As Austria-born British art historian Ernst Gombrich observed, Botticelli's anatomical distortions — such as the unusually long neck and steep fall of Venus's shoulders — were not technical errors, but deliberate choices that "enhance the impression of an infinitely tender and delicate being, driven to our shores as a gift from Heaven." Through these expressive choices, Botticelli demonstrated how physical beauty could elevate the human soul toward divine contemplation.

Though celebrated during his prime, Botticelli's fortunes waned in his later years. Lorenzo de Medici, one of his most important patrons, died in 1492, and the artist struggled to find work. Soon after, he came under the influence of the fiery religious reforms of friar Girolamo Savonarola (1452–1498). After Savonarola's dramatic rise and execution in 1498, Florence changed, and so did Botticelli's art. His later paintings became more austere, devotional and emotionally troubled.

Botticelli, who never married, died in 1510 — ill, impoverished, and walking with crutches. By then, his style was rapidly overshadowed by the naturalistic innovations of High Renaissance masters like Raphael (1483-1520) and Michelangelo. He was largely forgotten for three centuries until the 19th-century Pre-Raphaelites revived interest in his work, restoring his reputation as a Renaissance master.

Botticelli in Bengaluru

Art enthusiasts in Bengaluru have a rare opportunity to view an authentic Botticelli at the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA). His masterwork Madonna and Child serves as the centrepiece of the landmark exhibition One Mother, Many Mother Tongues, which brings together representations of motherhood across cultures and centuries.

Among other eye-catching exhibits on display are the sandstone Vrishabha Yogini from Satna, Madhya Pradesh; the fourth-century limestone Hariti from Takkellapadu, Telangana; and the third-century Etruscan Mater Matuta, an ancient Italian mother-and-child figure associated with protection, renewal and fertility.

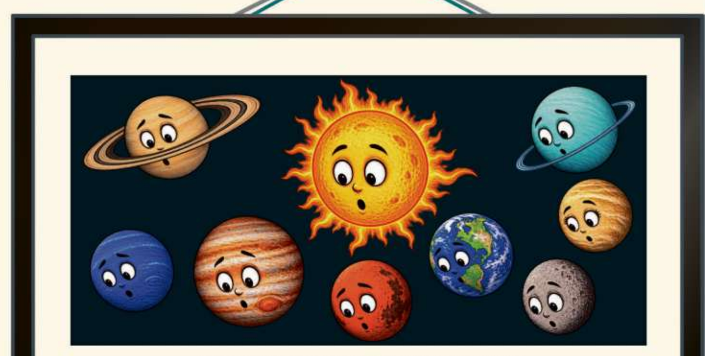
One Mother, Many Mother Tongues is on view at NGMA, Bengaluru, till September 20, 2026.

ESOTERICA *A monthly exploratory infographic for the always curious*

HOW PLUTO LOST ITS PLANET STATUS

On August 24, 2006, nine words spoken in a Prague assembly hall invalidated what all adults today would have read in their school textbooks. "Pluto is a dwarf planet and not a planet." With this verdict, the International Astronomical Union (IAU) gave a new definition for the term planet, restricted the list of planets orbiting the Sun to 8, and removed Pluto from the list. Many planetary scientists protested the move; many others supported it. The decision remains contentious.

To mark 20 years of the event, we dug deeper and discovered that the demotion was no astronomical discovery. Much like a palace coup, it had drama, intrigue, politics and plenty of bureaucratic tussle over semantics.



THE SUN, WITH ITS PLANET FAMILY

1 THE BACK STORY

Trouble began in the early 1990s when astronomers realised that Pluto was not merely a solitary body on the fringes of the solar system. It was the nearest, brightest part of the Kuiper Belt, a sort of cosmic junkyard with numerous frozen debris, icy asteroids, and planetary fragments orbiting the Sun beyond Neptune.

Then came 2005, when astronomer Mike Brown discovered Eris, an icy body slightly smaller than Pluto but with 27% more mass.

Science faced an awkward fork in the road. Either textbooks needed to welcome Eris (and, eventually, dozens of similar ice-spheres) as the tenth, eleventh, and twelfth planets, or humanity needed to do something it had surprisingly never done before: write a precise scientific definition of the word 'planet'. ■

2 A NEAR-MISS

After months of mulling over how to define a planet, the IAU's seven-member Planet Definition Committee met in Prague on August 16, 2006, to propose a draft definition.

The draft suggested that any object would be a planet if it:

- orbited a star and
- had enough mass for its gravity to pull it into a nearly round shape

Under these requirements, Pluto, its own moon Charon, an asteroid Ceres, and Eris all qualified as planets. But eight days later, on August 24, the final definition became Pluto's death knell. ■

3 HOW TWELVE PLANETS BECAME EIGHT

Following the draft proposal, a schism erupted in the IAU. Members studying Planetary Dynamics, or the physics of the solar system, fiercely objected to the draft definition. To them, physical shape mattered far less than how much a celestial body's gravity influenced the motion of smaller bodies around it. A true planet, they argued, must exhibit gravitational dominance. Pluto certainly did not dominate its part of the Solar System. Meanwhile, the IAU's Planetary Geologists favoured a geophysical definition of 'planet'.

The dynamicists, though, held sway, organising clandestine, late-night drafting sessions and lobbying uncommitted members over coffee and beer in Prague cafes. Eventually, realising that the dynamicists had the political momentum, the committee yielded. On the day of voting, a third decisive rule was added for planet status: "A planet must clear the neighbourhood around its orbit." Tiny Pluto dominates nothing. So, it got bundled out of the planet family. Incidentally, of the 2,000 astronomers attending the Prague assembly, only 424 participated in the final proceedings. The geologists were left feeling ambushed. No wonder, they are still arguing for a re-examination of the planet criteria. ■

TEXT & DESIGN: SIDDHARTH MOHANTY | Sources: loc.gov, psi.edu, astronomy.com

MUSEUM MATTERS

Sculpting new myths

The Victoria & Albert Museum in London is exhibiting the work of Indian-British artist Bharti Kher, bringing four significant sculptures spanning nearly two decades into dialogue with the museum's historic collections.

The display, installed primarily across the Dorothy and Michael Hintze Sculpture Galleries at V&A South Kensington, includes Warrior with Cloak and Shield (2008), Animus Mundi (2018), Ghost (2024) and Gaia (2026). The monumental bronze Gaia is installed in the Exhibition Road Courtyard. Drawing on mythology, womanhood and cultural identity, Kher's sculptural practice explores transformation, belonging and the shifting boundaries between the human and the natural world. The female body lies at its centre, often appearing in hybrid, fragmented or fantastical forms that bring the physical and metaphysical into conversation.

Bharti Kher looks at Gaia installed at the Exhibition Road Courtyard. (PIC BY DAVID LEVENE)

Living and working between London and New Delhi, Kher draws on both European sculptural traditions and South Asian visual languages, incorporating elements such as saris and bindis alongside cast bodies and found objects. Her works bring together disparate cultural narratives, creating forms that are at once familiar and otherworldly.

Gaia embodies the strength of a warrior and the generative force of a primordial mother goddess. Through the figure, Kher reflects on home, belonging, protection and resilience, while inviting viewers to consider the worlds they create within and beyond themselves.

DHNS

MOTLEY GARDEN

How the potato taught the camera to see colour

A journey from ancient Andean valleys to early photography reveals the largely unknown but world-shaping history of our favourite kitchen tuber, writes Subhashini Chandramani

White flowers of the potato plant.

Reading about plants and their histories gives me goosebumps. It feels like digging into the earth and discovering stories hidden beneath familiar leaves and flowers. Last month, I wrote about the black nightshade, *Solanum nigrum*, whose stem held the tiger moth's cocoon. I led you through the moth's story but barely spoke about the plant.

Black nightshade belongs to the astonishing genus *Solanum*, along with potato, tomato, and brinjal. It comes as a surprise that three vegetables that seem to have little in common belong to the same genus.

The potato, for instance, looks as though its greatest ambition is to be stuffed into a spicy samosa or dropped into a masala curry. It gives no hint that becoming the familiar aloo in our kitchens took thousands of years of human selection, observation, and ingenious processing. Its ancestors grew in the high Andes of South America. Indigenous Andean farmers began domesticating potatoes around 8,000 years ago. They cultivated thousands of varieties suited to different soils, altitudes, and degrees of cold. Some of the varieties that tolerated severe frost were too bitter to be eaten directly. Potatoes defend themselves with chemicals called glycoalkaloids. These compounds help discourage insects and grazing animals from feeding on the plants. Unfortunately, at sufficiently high concentrations, they discourage humans too. The Andean farmers did not know "glycoalkaloid". They could not measure glycoalkaloid concentrations in parts per million like modern scientists. They had something else: bitter taste, freezing nights, running water and generations of people who paid very close attention. Potatoes were left outdoors, where they froze at night and thawed and dried during the day.

After several cycles, the softened tubers were trodden upon to remove moisture and loosen their skins. Some were soaked and washed in flowing water before being dried again. This reduced their bitterness and glycoalkaloid content, while transforming them into chuño, a light, dry food that could be stored for years. Equally fascinating is how the Andean farmers, without knowing the language of genetics, gradually reshaped a defensive wild tuber into one of the world's most important food crops. Over thousands of years, farmers selected potatoes that tasted better and less bitter to propagate. They saved tubers from desirable plants and replanted them. By the time the Inca Empire arose, this knowledge was already ancient. The Incas used chuño as a portable food reserve. Andean ingenuity had taught the potato to survive time.

Centuries later, the potato was recruited to help something else survive time: colour.

In 1907, the brothers Auguste and Louis Lumière introduced Autochrome, the first commercially successful process for colour photography. At the heart of its colour screen was an unexpectedly ordinary material, potato starch. The brothers selected microscopic potato-starch grains, dyed them orange-red, green and blue-violet, and packed them closely across a glass plate. Each translucent grain acted as a tiny colour filter. Light from the scene passed through this mosaic before reaching the photographic emulsion. When the developed transparency was held to the light, the same starch grains filtered it once more, recreating the colours of the scene for the viewer. The potato did not enter the camera as food. It entered as an optical material. A tuber formed in darkness had helped a camera see colour.

The violet flowers of the aubergine plant.

Back in the vegetable garden, tomato, brinjal, and potato bear similar star-shaped flowers, with their yellow anthers gathered into a cone. Pollen is locked inside these anthers and escapes through tiny pores. A blue-banded bee, such as Amegilla zonata, grips the cone and vibrates her flight muscles without taking off. The flower shudders, and pollen bursts out like salt from a shaker. The kinship among the plants is also evident in the diseases they share. Bacterial wilt, caused by members of the *Ralstonia solanacearum* species complex, can infect all three. I return to the black nightshade, *Solanum nigrum*, with which this story began, its ripe black berries shining among the leaves. Last month, I saw it mainly as the stem that held a tiger moth's cocoon. Now its relatives have led me from the Andes to colour photography and back to the soil beneath my feet. The plants have not changed; the way I see them has.

Motley Garden *is your monthly kaleidoscopic view into a sustainable garden ecosystem. The author believes gardens are shared spaces where plants and creatures thrive together. She can be reached at allthingsinmygarden@gmail.com or on social media at @allthingsinmygarden*

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